One way to ensure contract changes that doesn’t break anything within the applications is to run regression tests across the risk areas. The contracts within Pact Broker can facilitate the release process and provide more confidence that specific contract differences don’t cause problems. Finally, the contract-sharing process can be integrated into CI solutions. Pact Broker provides a command-line interface (CLI) that offers easy access to provider verification statuses and webhooks to trigger dependent CI pipelines.

9.1.1 Pact Broker core features

When using a monolith application, keeping track of versions and changes in dependencies is easy. However, with microservices, there are many moving parts and code changes to align. Pact Broker offers some core features that help keep track of all the dependencies.

First, a key reason why contract testing gets introduced from a provider’s perspective is to account for all the consumers who interact with their service. This understanding of consumers can be difficult to achieve when working in a large-scale microservices environment. Visualizing who all the consumers are can be achieved by distributed tracing and monitoring how services are connected. Pact Broker offers an excellent visualization of how services are connected, known as the network diagram. When consumers publish their contracts to Pact Broker, they provide the provider name as part of the contract. The consumer and provider names then become the points on the network diagram, as shown in figure 9.3. Visualizing the consumers in one place provides an easy way for provider teams to communicate changes to consumer teams.